

August 20, 2026

Cigna Healthcare
Cigna Appeals Unit
P.O. Box 188011
Chattanooga, TN 37422

RE: Formal Appeal of Claim Denial — Kristie Effertz (MRN MUSC2132487), Claim MUSC-F1C0-2

Patient	Kristie Effertz (DOB 1945-03-23)
MRN	MUSC2132487
Member ID / Group	CIG607831767 / GRP-43365
Claim number	MUSC-F1C0-2
Date of service	2026-07-15
Procedure billed	CPT 99214 — Office/outpatient visit, established patient, moderate complexity
Primary diagnosis	J06.9 — Acute upper respiratory infection, unspecified
Denied amount	\$472.15
Denial code	CARC 204 / RARC N130 — This service/equipment/drug is not covered under the patient's current benefit plan.
Appeal deadline	2027-02-11

Dear Appeals Review Committee:

SUMMARY OF APPEAL

MUSC Health is submitting this formal first-level appeal on behalf of patient Kristie Effertz (MRN: MUSC2132487, Member ID: CIG607831767, Group: GRP-43365) regarding the denial of claim MUSC-F1C0-2 for services rendered on July 15, 2026, at MUSC Health Rutledge Tower Ambulatory Care. Cigna Healthcare denied the claim in full — \$472.15 billed — citing CARC 204 ("This service/equipment/drug is not covered under the patient's current benefit plan") and RARC N130 ("Consult plan benefit documents/guidelines for information about restrictions for this service"), with the payer remark stating: "Service is excluded under the member's plan benefit document." MUSC Health respectfully disputes this determination and requests a full reversal and payment at the allowed amount of \$304.12.

CLINICAL BACKGROUND

Ms. Effertz is an 81-year-old established patient with a documented history of chronic sinusitis (active, onset 2007), hypertension (active, onset 1963), hyperlipidemia (active, onset 2002), and osteoporosis (active, onset 2015). She presented on July 15, 2026, for an outpatient office visit with rendering provider Amara J. Boone, NP (NPI 1203948576) at an on-campus outpatient hospital facility (Place of Service 22). The visit was coded as CPT 99214, an established-patient office or outpatient visit of moderate complexity, with a primary diagnosis of J06.9 (acute upper respiratory infection, unspecified). Given Ms. Effertz's age and her constellation of active chronic conditions — including hypertension, hyperlipidemia, chronic sinusitis, and osteoporosis — evaluation and management of an acute upper respiratory illness in this patient population appropriately supports the moderate-complexity level of service assigned.

BASIS FOR APPEAL

The denial characterizes CPT 99214 as a non-covered service under Ms. Effertz's benefit plan. MUSC Health respectfully submits that this determination is inconsistent with the nature of the service provided and the coverage in force. Ms. Effertz's Cigna Healthcare Choice Plus plan carries a coverage period of January 1, 2024, through December 31, 2026, confirming active coverage on the date of service. CPT 99214 is a standard evaluation and management code representing a routine established-patient office visit — a category of service that is universally recognized as a core covered benefit under commercial health plans and is not, by its nature, a service type subject to categorical exclusion. MUSC Health has not received any plan benefit document, exclusion rider, or prior-authorization requirement from Cigna that would support the exclusion of outpatient evaluation and management services for this member. The payer's remark directs the provider to consult plan benefit documents, yet no specific exclusion language has been communicated to MUSC Health or the patient. A blanket denial citing a benefit exclusion, without identifying the specific exclusionary provision that applies to a standard E/M visit, does not constitute a sufficient or actionable denial under generally accepted claims adjudication standards. MUSC Health requests that Cigna identify, in writing, the precise benefit exclusion language relied upon to deny this claim. If no such exclusion applies to outpatient office visits of this type, the claim should be reversed and paid at the contracted allowed amount of \$304.12.

REQUESTED ACTION

MUSC Health respectfully requests that Cigna Healthcare conduct a thorough review of this appeal, identify any specific plan exclusion language upon which the denial is based, and reverse the denial of claim MUSC-F1C0-2. Payment of \$304.12 — the allowed amount previously calculated by Cigna — should be issued promptly upon reversal. Should Cigna uphold the denial, MUSC Health requests a written explanation citing the exact benefit exclusion provision applicable to outpatient evaluation and management services for this member, along with information regarding the next level of appeal available under the plan and applicable state and federal external review rights.

Respectfully submitted,

Angela R. Whitfield, RN, BSN, CPC

Senior Appeals Specialist, Revenue Cycle Management
MUSC Health — Revenue Cycle / Patient Financial Services
(843) 792-2300 | muschealth.org

Enclosures

- Remittance advice / explanation of payment
- Itemized claim detail (UB-04 / CMS-1500)
- Relevant clinical documentation from the medical record